American and Indian officials also shared their assessments of the state of Sino-Soviet relations. For example, the Indian ambassador in Beijing reported the departure of hundreds of Soviet experts from China.[126] This information sharing was taking place at the highest levels as well. When Eisenhower and Herter met Nehru, the secretary of state asked for the prime minister's view of Sino-Soviet ties. Nehru confirmed that the two countries were "not getting along." The two leaders also discussed if (and when) Moscow would get concerned about a more powerful China.[127]

Pakistan's Role

Eisenhower was skeptical that Moscow could be an effective solution to India's China problem,[128] but there was hope in Washington that Pakistan could be part of the solution for India. A May 1959 intelligence estimate indicated that a joint India-Pakistan effort could materialize if they perceived a direct Chinese threat.[129] Eisenhower instructed that American officials make "special efforts" to bring Delhi and Rawalpindi together and to get them to understand that their "true enemies" were Beijing and Moscow.[130] American hopes for a South Asian settlement increased when India and Pakistan agreed in August 1959 to begin drafting the Indus Waters Treaty. The Indian embassy reported to Delhi that there was a sense in Washington that this agreement was a result of the Chinese threat.[131]

In Delhi in December 1959, Eisenhower stressed to Nehru that the real threat came from the north. The Indian prime minister pointed to progress in India-Pakistan relations, but made clear that the American idea of joint India-Pakistan defense planning would be incompatible with nonalignment. He instead proposed a joint no-war declaration, which Eisenhower subsequently recommended to Pakistani leader Ayub Khan.[132]

Indian officials accepted that the China threat made a settlement with Pakistan more desirable, but it also made one less feasible. A friendly Pakistan would make India "feel more safe 'in her rear,'" Indian ambassador to the US M. C. Chagla acknowledged. There was also the opposite concern that Nehru expressed to Eisenhower of a Pakistani "stab in the back" while India was tackling the Chinese threat. But, as Bunker noted, Sino-Indian tension made Nehru less likely to concede India's claim on Kashmir—he was already facing considerable domestic pressure and would not want to set a precedent by giving up territory.[133]